all parameters still need to be stored even though only a subset is activated for each token.

Ask instead: how much context will I normally use?

For routine chat and writing, modest context may be enough. For books, research archives or substantial code repositories, longer context becomes more valuable. Buy for your workload, not the largest number on the box.

Step 5: Decide how much reasoning you actually need

Reasoning models can spend additional computation working through difficult problems. That can be excellent for maths, code and structured planning, but it also introduces latency.



gpt-oss offers configurable reasoning effort, for example, while Mistral Small 4 combines instruct, reasoning, coding and multimodal capabilities and lets users vary reasoning effort. Mistral Small 4 is a 119B-parameter MoE model with 6.5B active parameters and a 256K context window, released under Apache 2.0.

That sounds like a model you should always choose over a non-reasoning alternative. It is not.

If your daily workload is "summarise this," "rewrite this paragraph" and "extract the dates from these notes," speed may matter more than extended deliberation. A smaller instruction model that answers instantly can be more useful than a heavyweight reasoning system.

A good local setup therefore often pairs a fast everyday model with a slower "think harder" model.

Step 6: Treat multimodal capability as a requirement, not a bonus

If you want AI to inspect images, screenshots or scanned pages, make that a hard filter.

A text-only model cannot magically see an image because your runtime displays an attachment button. The model architecture must support visual input and the runtime must support the model's vision components.

Gemma 4 and Mistral Small 4 are contemporary examples of multimodal open models. Llama 4 Scout and Maverick also accept text and images. Qwen3.6-35B-A3B is listed as an image-text-to-text model on Hugging Face.

Before downloading, check three things:

1. Does the exact model variant support images?
2. Does your chosen runtime support its vision projector or multimodal architecture?
3. Will the additional model components still fit comfortably in memory?

If the answer to any of those is no, choose another model.

Step 7: India needs its own test

For Indian readers, "multilingual" on a model card is only the beginning.

A model may technically support Hindi but struggle with colloquial Hinglish, transliteration, Indian names, local institutions or less represented languages. You should therefore test language capability yourself rather than assuming that a global benchmark reflects your usage.

Sarvam's open 30B and 105B reasoning models are particularly relevant. Both were trained from scratch in India on compute provided under the IndiaAI Mission. Sarvam says a substantial part of their multilingual training budget went towards the ten most-spoken Indian languages, while its tokenizer is optimised across all 22 scheduled Indian languages.

For translation, a specialist may again beat a generalist. AI4Bharat's IndicTrans2 supports all 22 scheduled Indian languages and releases its model checkpoints, datasets and evaluation benchmarks openly; its checkpoints use an MIT licence.

Use a five-prompt India test before adopting any general-purpose model:

